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The king in every man

Author(S): Henderson, Richard N.

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 297

Culture (OWC): [Igbo \(FF26\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1960-1962

Coverage Date: 1500-1880

Place Coverage: Onitsha Clty, Anambra State, Nigeria

Section Title(S): THE KING AS AGENT OF EXTERNAL RELATIONS

All the communities contiguous to precolonial Onitsha were strongly linked in ritual dependence to the kings at Nri. Nri representatives had to officiate at the ɔ̀zɔ̀ title ceremonies in these towns and enter them as priests to supervise the "covering of abominations"; in some cases the Nri king himself entered the community during his accession to make sacrifice at major communal shrines. Throughout Iboland, it appears that kings expanded their sovereignty first by establishing the right to give sacrifices to the shrines of new communities, thereby gaining rights to receive homage service. Expansion of such rights by Onitsha east of the Niger was almost certainly inhibited by the prior existence of such powers in the hands of the Nri kings.

175
[History](#)

628
[Inter-Community Relations](#)

Indeed, the Nri king based at Orieri included Onitsha as part of his sacrificial round during his succession to the throne and therefore considered it part of his domain.³⁰ He was expected to make sacrifices at major Onitsha shrines, including Onitsha land and the river Niger. As Jeffreys describes it, when the Nri king wished to perform his final great ceremony of sacrifice to the river, he would find that "Eze Onitsha locked one of my followers up in a room and said I would have to ransom him." According to Jeffreys, "This procedure is customary, each Eze Ndri Orieri must rescue or ransom his man from the Eze Onitsha."³¹

175
[History](#)

628
[Inter-Community Relations](#)

These patterns suggest a structured ambiguity in the relations between the Onitsha and Nri kings. By early exploratory times a kind of joking relationship had developed between the two, in which the king of Onitsha permitted the king of Nri to sacrifice at the major shrines to land and river in recognition of

175
[History](#)

628

his spiritual superiority, but seized the latter's followers for ransom as a sign of his superior strength. Nri spiritual superiority extended ²⁹⁸to the requirement that Nri men enter Onitsha to supervise any "covering of abomination" that involved the use of scapegoats or humans in sacrifice, but it did not include the right to confer ụ́zọ́ title, for the kings in Onitsha severally held their own nze. The Onitsha king also controlled a spirit shrine along the Niger called "It eats Nri [people]," alluding to its capacity to consume Nri men who misbehaved while in the community.

30. Jeffreys (n.d.:12:14).

31. Ibid.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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